Building the sabat was lethal work, in fact, and Akbar paid for it accordingly: ‘silver and gold were reckoned at the rate of earth’, writes Abul Fazl; or, he might have added, of life. Between 100 and 200 men would die every day, building the tunnel, and even in death they would serve Akbar’s single-minded vision of conquest, their bodies stuffed into the walls of their sabat, like bricks.

Whatever the cost, Akbar had decided that a sabat was ‘the best mode of capturing a fortress’. Two commanders, Todar Mal and Qasim Khan, were deputed to supervise its construction, and Akbar himself inspected its progress regularly: ‘frequently’ he rode through its macabre walls, climbed upon its roof and fired at the fort’s defenders.[31] It was Akbar and his musket on his sabat that managed to kill Chittor’s star shooter, Ismail, leader of the fort’s artillery corps and a menace to the Mughal troops.[32] And finally, one night, it was Akbar and his musket on his sabat that won Chittor.

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It was the last week of February, four months after Akbar arrived at Chittorgarh in a storm. Its defenders and the Mughal troops remained equally well matched, equally unrelenting. The night before, every single Mughal contingent surrounding the fort had charged upon it simultaneously. The fighting had raged all night and day; and now on the second night of continuous battle, the sabat had snaked its way close enough to the fort for Akbar’s soldiers to breach one of its walls.

Akbar was perched on top of his tunnel, musket in hand, watching the stone from the broken wall fall.

Jaimal’s soldiers gathered at the site of the damage, fending off Mughal attacks and filling the breach with ‘muslin, cotton, wood and oil’,[33] intending to erect a wall of fire to replace the stone. A man wearing a breastplate called ‘*hazaar-mikhi*’, spiked with 1000 nails and reserved for chiefs,[34] strode amongst the Rajputs. Every so often, fire or fusillade would light up the bastion.[35]

At each burst of light, Akbar aimed his musket. ‘A mortar brazen-bodied, dragon-faced’,[36] a poet would write of it. Its weight would have been familiar in Akbar’s hand; it was his favourite gun[37] and he had named it Sangram. War.